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Strong drink, beer

9.2 Strong drink, beer

References:

Hebrew סֹבֶא (sove') ISA 1:22, HOS 4:18, NAM 1:10

Hebrew שֵׁכָר (shekar) LEV 10:9, NUM 6:3, NUM 6:3, NUM 28:7, DEU 14:26, DEU 29:5, JDG 13:4, JDG 13:7, JDG 13:14, 1SA 1:15, PSA 69:13, PRO 20:1, PRO 31:4, PRO 31:6, ISA 5:11, ISA 5:22, ISA 24:9, ISA 28:7, ISA 28:7, ISA 28:7, ISA 29:9, ISA 56:12, MIC 2:11

Greek σίκερα (sikera) LUK 1:15

Description:

Beer was an intoxicating fermented drink made from grain. It was usually less strong (that is, had a lower alcholic content) than wine.

Translation:

Many languages will have a general expression such as "strong drink." Distilled alcoholic beverages, such as whiskey, gin and vodka, were not known in the ancient world.

LEV 10:9: The Hebrew word translated "wine" by RSV indicates a drink made from grapes, and the context makes it clear that fermentation is probably involved. The next Hebrew term, rendered "strong drink" in RSV, refers to a fermented drink made from barley. The most common equivalent in many languages is "beer." But these two terms used together represent any alcoholic beverages, and the prohibition is not limited to two kinds. The translation should make it clear that a general rule is intended. If a language has terms for wine and beer, or for wines of lesser and greater alchoholic content, these may be used here. It is not necessary to have two terms, however, if it is difficult to find two. "All kinds of intoxicating drinks" is another possibility.

LUK 1:15: Even though the Greek word sikera may have a generic meaning and thus refer to any type of intoxicating drink, in the New Testament it occurs only here, where it contrasts with wine and refers to intoxicating beverages made from grain. Several translations have "beer" (CEV, NCV). NIV says "other fermented drink," and PV has "any other alcohol."